PORTFOLIO CASE STUDY

Deckhunter

Designing and shipping a production AI-native mobile app — solo.

iOS & Android

Live on App Store & Google Play

One Piece TCG · Gundam TCG · Riftbound TCG

Cursor & Claude Code

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01 THE PROBLEM

Mind-numbingly tedious

I've been a TCG player for years and have amassed over 5,000 cards in just one game. The moment I'd find an exciting decklist online, I'd hit the same wall every time.

The app already knows my collection. Why cant I just give it a decklist and let it tell me what Im missing?

Existing apps managed collections well enough but none of them bridged the gap between a decklist you find online and the cards you actually own. Every player was doing this manually: switching between apps, cross-referencing card by card, writing things down, hoping they didn't miss anything.
It seemed like a simple problem. I decided to try and solve it.

BEFORE

- ✗ Find decklist online
- ✗ Open collection app
- ✗ Switch back to deck list website or picture
- ✗ Check each card manually
- ✗ Write down what's missing
- ✗ Hope you didn't miss anything

WITH DECKHUNTER

- → Import any decklist
- → Instant owned vs. missing analysis
- → One-tap shareable want list image
- → **Done.**

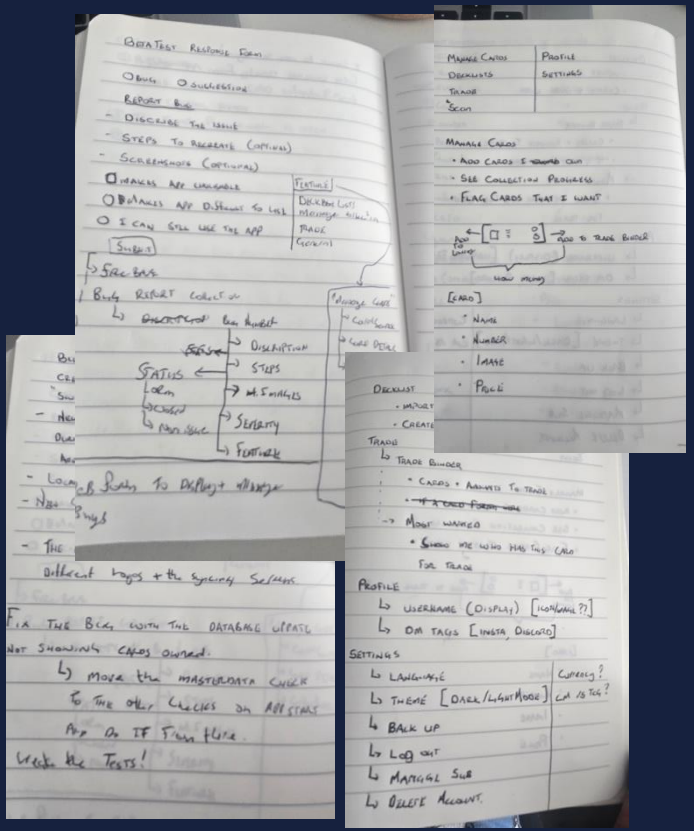
30+ min → ~30 sec

What about everything else…

I sat down with my notebook and started listing out all the frustrations I had and how I might be able to solve this for myself

A FEW OF MY THOUGHTS

- I play multiple games, and pay for multiple apps that do the something – can it all be together?
- It's a pain constantly looking for images of cards so I can post in trade groups when I'm trying to find them
- I keep losing track of the cards I actually need for my decks and sometimes I buy cards twice
- I've accidently traded cards I needed for ones I did not…on more then one occasion
- *…I wonder if others have the same issues…*



Architect.
Not just a prompt-sender.

I'm a designer, not an engineer. But I had a clear vision for the product. The question was how to build it without a development team. The answer was to treat AI as a collaborative technical partner and approach the project exactly the way I would a professional design engagement.
I brought my design methodology to the collaboration. The user journeys came first. The PRD was the blueprint. Claude Code was the contractor. I was the architect.

01 DESIGN FIRST

User journeys, information architecture, flows and wireframes before a single line of code.

02 PRD AS BLUEPRINT

Used AI to generate a formal PRD from design docs and ‘interviews’. The PRD governed the build.

03 FEATURE BY FEATURE

One feature at a time. Brief → plan → build → test on real device → iterate → next phase.

04 VERIFICATION AT EVERY STEP

Before each feature was built, I described it and asked: "Is there a better approach?" Final call was always mine.

One app.
Three games.
Each with different rules.

One Piece TCG, Gundam TCG, and Riftbound TCG each have different card schemas, different mechanics, and different deck-building rules. A player who only plays one game shouldn't think about the others at all, players who play all should navigate with ease.

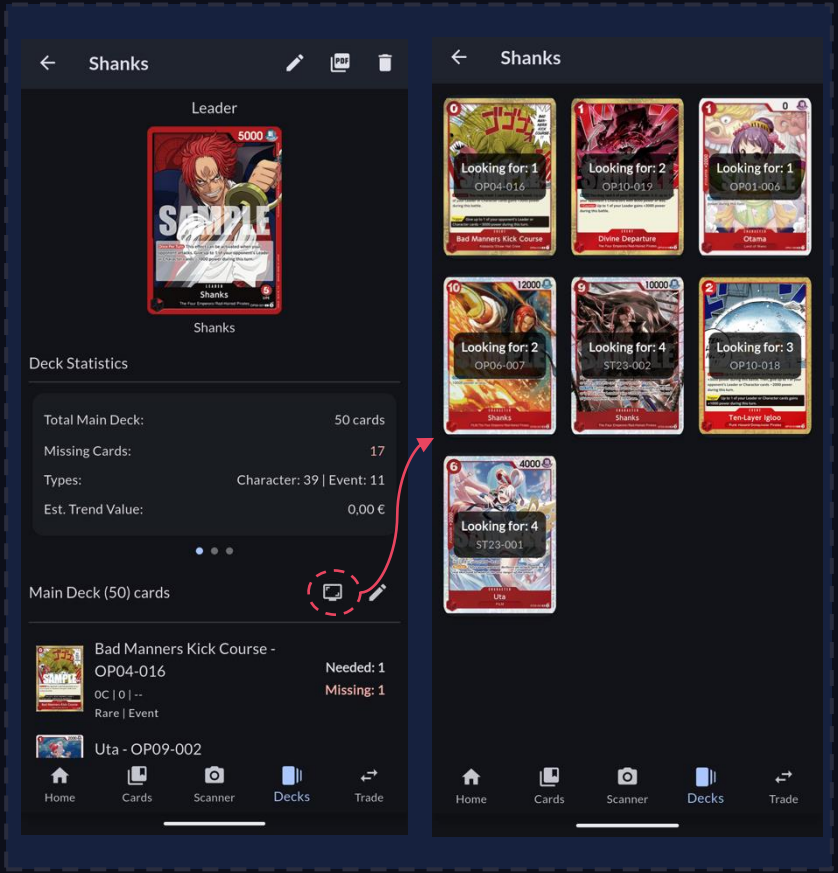
For all games, a player must be able to manages their collections, creates deck lists for play, identify missing cards for the decks and collection, facilitates trading and pricing, all in seconds

The broader visual language takes its cues from the cards themselves. When you're playing, a card needs to communicate its key information at a glance. That same principle drives the UI: the most meaningful information in any given context should be the thing that's immediately visible, without hunting for it.

Designed for the real world.

> *TCG trading doesn't happen in apps. It happens in trusted social groups like those on Discord servers and WhatsApp groups. The design question wasn't 'what looks good in the app?' — it was **'what format integrates into how people actually trade cards?'***

One tap. Generates a clean image of every missing card with quantities, ready to drop into any chat. No manual listing. No hunting for card images. Always Accurate.



04 PROTOTYPING METHOD

3 live branches.
Not 3 Figma files.

TRADITIONAL APPROACH

Build assets in Figma
Create interactive prototype
Share link for feedback
Users test simulated interactions
Weeks to test 3 variants

MY APPROACH

Spin up 3 working code branches
Each on a real device simultaneously
Real players test real interactions
Bad ideas killed same day
3 variants tested in hours

Bad ideas are killed quickly and good ideas are already implemented...

The app is half the system.

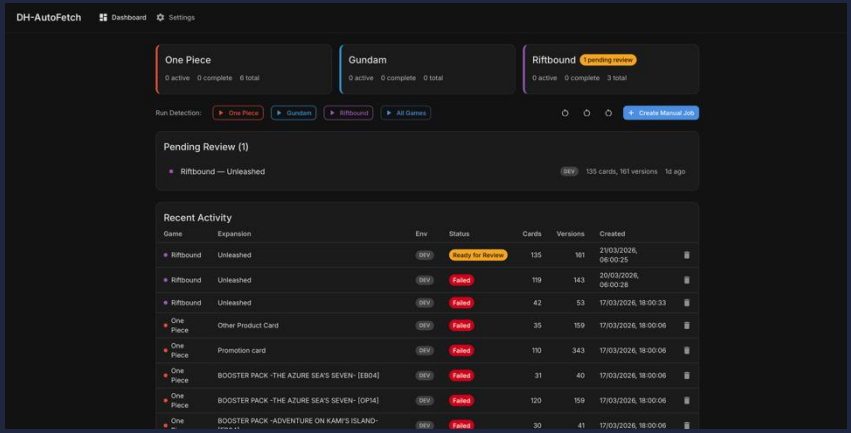
Three games. Three different release schedules. An entire data pipeline to keep the app fed with accurate, priced card data. I built all of it...well I used Claude to build all of it

DH-AUTOFETCHER

Automated card data pipeline

→ Monitors official sources for new set releases
→ Fetches and processes data automatically
→ Pulls pricing from external sources
→ Discord webhook notification when ready
→ I review before anything goes to production

This started as a series of manual scripts I'd run step by step, so I could understand the process and validate it was working correctly. Once I was confident in the pipeline, I automated it. The manual-first approach meant I understood every step before handing it to automation; a discipline that came directly from my design practice.



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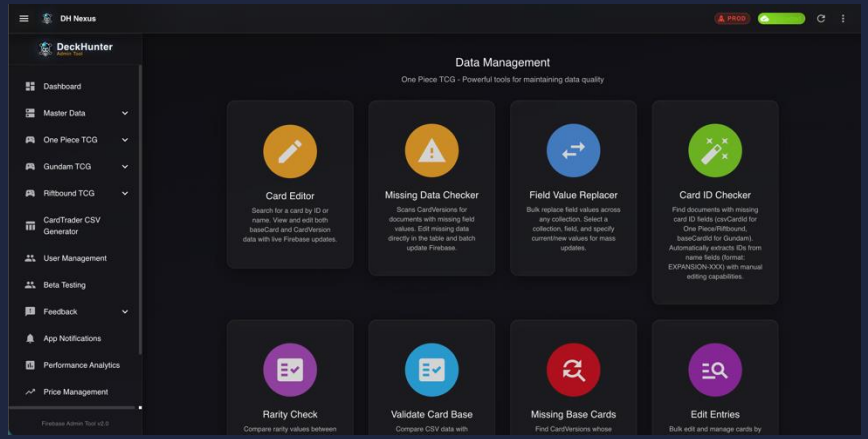


DHNEXUS

Admin console

→ Data tools with simulation preview before commit
→ Feedback dashboard — bugs, suggestions, comments
→ Collection health checks across all game data
→ Set management and production publishing
→ *See the result before you commit it*

When it all comes together

06 “MY OH WOW!” MOMENTS

Things that made me smile.

USERS FOUND IT WITHOUT MARKETING

Organic discovery. Organic paying subscribers. Before a single post went out.

THE FIRST BUG REPORT

A user took the time to report a small bug. The feedback loop I'd designed was working. That felt significant.

"THE TEAM DID A GREAT WORK"

Multiple users wrote in addressing 'the team.' Nobody knew it was one person. That's a signal about the quality bar — not a cute anecdote.

AI amplifies judgment. It doesn't replace it.

Deckhunter wouldn't exist without AI. Not because I used AI tools, but because AI genuinely changed what was possible for a designer working alone.

WHAT I BROUGHT

- → Design thinking: user journeys, IA, interaction decisions
- → Product judgment: what to build, defer, and cut
- → The quality bar: real device testing with real users
- → Operational design: the system behind the screen
- → **Every final decision**

WHAT AI CONTRIBUTED

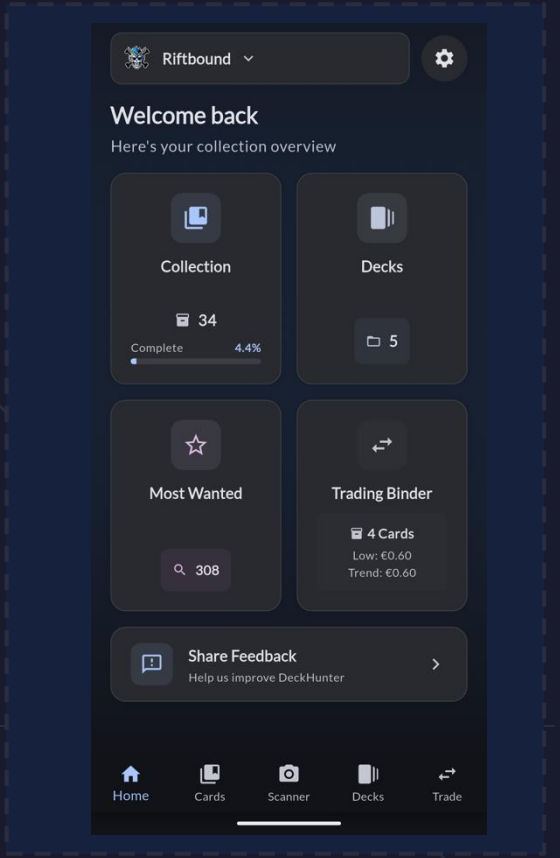
- → Implementation speed: turning specs into working code
- → Technical research: tradeoffs I couldn't evaluate alone
- → Alternative approaches: pushing back when better options existed
- → Breadth: backend, pipeline, admin console, and app in parallel

The most important thing I learned: AI amplifies judgment. If you bring strong design thinking to the collaboration, AI makes you much more powerful. If you don't, AI makes the gap more visible.

DECKHUNTER

Live. Continuous delivery. Users assuming a team built it.

One designer. One AI collaborator. A production mobile app, a data pipeline, and an admin console.



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